

WatchGuard also offers unified threat management solutions including signature-based intrusion detection systems (IDS), and a ‘State of Network’ test, which is bundled free with its Firebox. WatchGuard’s dynamic ‘Live security service’ provides regular updates and virus alerts, identifies vulnerabilities, spyware, and intrusions. Pillai elaborates, “Product updates, anti-spam and anti-virus tools can be enabled by installing software keys, thereby eliminating inventory issues.”

"Our critical resources are accessed by about 35 users—they access Web sites, use FTP clients (two users), CRM applications (25 users), and access mail and domain servers as well. All functionalities are mapped and external users are authenticated at every stage," says Rajan.

End User Involvement

In order to engage end-users in the security framework, WatchGuard's resellers conduct training sessions, and also help update the particular company's security resources.

Rajan agrees that end user involvement is essential. He explains, “We use a Virtual Private Network (VPN) so that our Customer Relationship Management (CRM) server can be accessed by our sales team across India. Users

Time now, perhaps, to shift to the next lot of SHA variants—SHA-224, SHA-256, SHA-384, and SHA-512—cumulatively called as SHA-2.

Educating Your Employees

End users are extremely vulnerable nodes in any network. Enforcing protocols, like not opening suspicious attachments, updating virus definitions regularly, using 'safe' sites for e-commerce transactions, not responding to spam, and perhaps subscribing to security updates/newsletters from a trusted vendor would help prevent many attacks. Also, employees should report virus attacks immediately, and download relevant patches. Setting complex passwords for accounts, and using encryption keys for transfer of confidential documents is equally imperative.

Access to key network resources should be restricted to one or two people (preferably the CTO and the System Administrator) and all security breaches should be reported to the concerned authority.

It goes without saying that pirated software is a no-no. Regular updates of existing software will safeguard your PC safe from newer, malignant malware.

Regular security audits—internal or external—are a must for any firm. With a slew of viruses and Trojans hitting the Internet on a daily basis, audits will let the administrative department know, how vulnerable a system is, to attacks. Again, the SysAdmin needs to involve users in security exercises.

access a remote server from their machines (with an SQL backend) and use PPTP (point-to-point tunnelling protocol) to access the server. However, firewall authentication is required at each and every stage.”

Active employee participation is critical for any secure network. After all, a network is as vulnerable as it's weakest link; the link, which most virus writers and spambots exploit—the end user. Audits aside, employee awareness programmes can go a long way in ensuring that a network stays secure and active.

As Pillai affirms, "The SMB segment in India is growing at a 30 to 40 per cent rate every year. Their employees are net-savvy and communicate with a global clientele. Moreover, the US and the UK-based companies are demanding rigorous security norms before awarding contracts to Indian firms."

SMBs such as DAX Networks, which may or may not flaunt a full-fledged 'IT team', are certainly reinforcing the 'better safe than sorry' norm. It is by investing time and resources in security solutions as well as enforcing stringent security procedures that SMBs can try and achieve minimum 'downtime' even when crippled by a severe violation of their security system.

“Security vendors have begun to realise that the ‘one size fits all’ paradigm doesn’t hold true in the SMB space. Customised solutions coupled with personal attention, and assisting SMBs to promote prudent network usage works best,” avers Pillai. ☒

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